

THE LOOP WE LIVE IN

*Voluntary Governance, Strange Loops,
and the Architecture Installed in 1913*

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"A framework for understanding how authority, education, money, and consent became self-referential — and what that means for the future."

Abstract

This document explores how authority, education, money, and consent became self-referential in the United States — forming what complexity theorist Douglas Hofstadter would recognize as a strange loop: a hierarchical system that folds back on itself, using its own outputs to validate its own existence.

The central argument is that most Americans already possess the constitutional framework for genuine voluntary self-governance. The Ninth and Tenth Amendments, read plainly and seriously, carve out enormous territory for communities to organize outside the coercive state apparatus. The First Amendment's freedom of association extends that space further. The architecture of voluntary governance is not something that needs to be invented — it is already written into the founding documents and has been systematically ignored, underpublicized, and practically obstructed by the institutional accumulation of the past century.

The document then traces how that accumulation happened. The year 1913 is identified as a pivotal inflection point in which three simultaneous changes — the Sixteenth Amendment (income tax), the Seventeenth Amendment (direct election of senators), and the Federal Reserve Act — fundamentally restructured the relationship between the individual, the state, and the money supply. These changes did not happen in isolation. They occurred against a background of accelerating financial consolidation, the documented influence of private banking interests on public policy, and the imminent arrival of World War One, which immediately made the new fiscal infrastructure load-bearing and therefore permanent.

The Hofstadter strange loop framework, drawn from Godel, Escher, Bach, is applied to show how the education system, the court system, and the monetary system each became self-referential in ways that prevent internal critique. Using Godel's incompleteness theorem as an analogy, the document argues that the truths most threatening to the current architecture are precisely the ones that cannot be acknowledged from within it — they appear as conspiracy, fringe, or instability rather than as legitimate structural observations.

The document closes by examining artificial intelligence as a potential Godel move — a new cognitive substrate that operates partially outside the loop the existing institutional order built — and considers what that means for governance, power, and the future of voluntary human coordination.

Preface: Why This Needs to Be Written

Most critiques of power fall into one of two traps. Either they argue from inside the system using the system's own assumptions as the ground floor of their logic, or they burn it all down in rhetoric that offers nothing constructive in its place. What follows is an attempt to do neither.

This document is an exploration — part philosophical, part historical, part structural — of how the world most people in America were born into came to be, why it perpetuates itself so effectively, and what genuine alternatives might look like when thought through carefully rather than shouted about carelessly.

The central argument is not that anyone is evil, or that a single moment created everything wrong, or that there is a clean exit. The central argument is that we are living inside a strange loop — a self-referential system that uses its own outputs to validate its own existence — and that understanding the loop is the prerequisite for anything else.

This is not a manifesto. Manifestos demand. This is a map.

Part One: The Idea of Voluntary Governance

What Anarchy Actually Means

The word anarchy has been so thoroughly weaponized as a synonym for chaos that its actual philosophical content has become almost inaccessible in public conversation. But the tradition is serious, coherent, and worth engaging honestly.

Classical anarchist thinkers — Kropotkin, Proudhon, Bakunin — grounded their work in a specific and testable claim: that human beings are capable of complex, cooperative social organization without coercive hierarchy. The state and capitalism are not necessary prerequisites for order. They are, in fact, obstacles to the organic, voluntary forms of order that human communities naturally produce when left to themselves.

Voluntary association for mutual benefit is the core. Not chaos. Not isolation. Not every man for himself. The opposite — genuine community organized from the bottom up by the consent and participation of its members rather than imposed from above by an institution with a monopoly on force.

The complication is that there are dozens of anarchist tendencies that disagree sharply about what voluntary association means in practice. Anarcho-communists argue that markets are themselves coercive because unequal starting conditions make participation less than fully free. Anarcho-capitalists argue that markets are the purest expression of voluntary exchange. Mutualists and syndicalists occupy various positions in between. The word voluntary carries enormous philosophical weight that doesn't resolve itself simply.

Constitutional Anarchy: An Unnamed Territory

Constitutional anarchy does not yet exist as a named, developed political philosophy with a substantial literature. But the concept is not incoherent, and the territory it would occupy is genuinely interesting.

A constitution is typically understood as a coercive governing document — a set of rules that apply to everyone whether or not they explicitly consent. That framing puts it in direct opposition to anarchist principles. But the opposition dissolves if you reframe what a constitution is for.

Imagine a constitution not as a legal instrument backed by force but as a foundational social covenant — a collectively authored set of principles defining the terms of voluntary association itself. Not a list of laws you must obey, but a living statement of conditions under which cooperation is offered and maintained, with explicit mechanisms for consent, revision, and exit.

Key features of such a framework might include no permanent institutions holding a monopoly on force, disputes resolved through federated community arbitration with no standing judiciary, the founding document itself continuously revisable by genuine consensus rather than locked behind supermajority amendment processes, and

transparent mechanisms by which communities can exit or restructure associations without penalty or coercion.

Adjacent concepts that already exist point in this direction. Panarchy — the idea that multiple governance systems coexist in the same territory and individuals choose which they belong to — is the closest analog. Polycentric law theory, developed by Bruno Leoni and later expanded by public choice economists, explores overlapping legal systems without central authority. Network states, a more recent concept, treat governance as a startup-like opt-in community with its own foundational rules and voluntary membership.

What none of these have produced is a Locke or a Madison — a systematic philosophical synthesis that makes constitutional anarchy as intellectually rigorous and practically detailed as the frameworks it would replace. That work remains ahead of us.

The Constitution Already Carves the Space

Here is what most people who argue about constitutional rights never fully reckon with: the existing United States Constitution already contains significant architecture for voluntary self-governance. The founders built the space. What was installed over the following two and a half centuries was a systematic occupation of that space by institutional power.

The Ninth Amendment explicitly states that the enumeration of certain rights in the Constitution shall not be construed to deny or disparage others retained by the people. Read carefully, this is a radical document. The federal government is acknowledging in its foundational text that it does not define the full scope of human freedom — only specific constraints on its own authority. An enormous territory of unenumerated rights exists that the government cannot touch.

The Tenth Amendment reserves all powers not delegated to the federal government to the states or to the people. The people. Not the states as a fallback. The people as a distinct category of sovereign authority.

The First Amendment's freedom of association permits the formation of communities, governance structures, dispute resolution systems, and social organizations outside the state apparatus.

These provisions, taken seriously and literally, already permit something very close to constitutional anarchy within the existing framework. The question is not whether the architecture exists. It does. The question is why so few people know it exists, and why the state remains the final arbiter of what these provisions mean even when that meaning requires overriding the plain text.

The answer to that question is where this document has to go next.

Part Two: The Education Problem and the Strange Loop

What Schools Are Actually Doing

The surface explanation for why people do not know or exercise their constitutional rights is simple: the education system does not teach it. The typical American civics curriculum covers the three branches of government, the amendment process, and a few highlighted rights in enough detail to pass a standardized test. The deeper philosophical content — the natural rights tradition, the Ninth Amendment's implications, the founders' specific fears about concentrated power — is largely absent.

But the surface explanation is insufficient. The deeper explanation requires asking why the curriculum looks the way it does, and whether that pattern is accidental.

Public education systems are institutional systems. Institutional systems, without any individual malicious intent, naturally select for outputs that serve the institution's continuation. Compliant, functional, adequately informed participants are easier to govern than genuinely critical, philosophically grounded ones. Not because anyone designed the curriculum to produce compliance — though in some cases they did — but because curriculum committees, textbook publishers, standardized testing bodies, and state education departments all exist within the institutional framework and naturally reproduce its assumptions.

The result is that most people graduate with a working knowledge of how to participate in the existing system — how to vote, pay taxes, navigate courts minimally — but without the philosophical foundation to question whether the system itself is legitimate, well-designed, or operating as its founders intended.

Hofstadter's Strange Loop

Douglas Hofstadter, in *Gödel, Escher, Bach*, describes a strange loop as what happens when you move through the levels of a hierarchical system — apparently ascending toward resolution — and then suddenly find yourself back where you started. The movement felt like progress but the system has folded back on itself. Higher level and lower level turn out to be the same level.

The classic example is Gödel's incompleteness theorem. Within any sufficiently complex formal mathematical system, there exist true statements that cannot be proven within that system. To see those truths, you must step outside the system entirely. The system cannot evaluate itself from within itself without encountering its own limits. When it tries, it generates statements that reference themselves — and in doing so, becomes trapped.

The education-authority loop is strange in exactly this sense. The state creates an education system to produce informed citizens capable of participating in democracy. But genuinely informed citizens would eventually question the legitimacy of the state itself. So the education system is structured — not through conspiracy but through

institutional self-preservation — to produce citizens who are informed enough to function within the system but not so critical as to question its foundations. Those citizens then vote for representatives who fund and shape the education system. Which produces the same kind of citizens. Which produces the same representatives.

You move through the levels — student, citizen, voter, legislator, policy — and arrive back at the same legitimating structure you started from. There is no external ground. The system is using its own output to validate its own existence.

Why It Is Strange, Specifically

What distinguishes a strange loop from a regular feedback loop is self-reference. The system is not just cycling — it is generating statements about itself that it cannot evaluate from within itself.

The citizens produced by the education system are the same ones who consent to the system that produced them. Their consent is the proof of the system's legitimacy. But their capacity for consent was shaped by the system whose legitimacy they are now being asked to validate. This is circular in a way that cannot be resolved internally. Like Godel's unprovable statements, the system's claim to legitimacy exists inside the system and cannot be proven by the system without assuming what it needs to prove.

Hofstadter's deepest insight was that strange loops do not merely produce logical paradox — they produce the feeling of a stable self. The brain references itself recursively until something emerges that experiences itself as a unified, continuous observer. That sense of selfhood is not discovered. It is generated by the loop.

The state does the same thing. Courts validate the constitution. The constitution authorizes the courts. Elected representatives appoint judges. Judges interpret what elections mean. The loop runs until it generates the feeling of legitimate, stable authority. That feeling is not evidence of legitimacy. It is the phenomenological output of the loop operating correctly.

The Exit Problem

To break a strange loop, you need a reference point outside it. Godel needed to step outside formal arithmetic to see what arithmetic could not see about itself. Breaking the authority loop requires a vantage point the loop did not provide.

This is why people who came up outside credentialed institutions — who had to reason from first principles because no institution handed them a framework — sometimes see the architecture more clearly than those who moved through the system successfully. The system never fully captured their epistemological ground floor. Their thinking has a reference point, however partial, that predates their encounter with the loop.

It is also why genuine intellectual dissent so rarely comes from inside institutions. The institution selects for people who internalized its assumptions early and deeply enough to succeed within it. Those people are then filtered for positions of authority. By the time someone reaches a position where they could change the system, they have typically been shaped by it too completely to see it as contingent rather than natural.

Part Three: The Courts — Theory Versus Reality

Where Judicial Authority Actually Comes From

Federal judges derive their authority from Article III of the Constitution. State court judges derive authority from state constitutions and statutes — one step removed from the federal constitutional framework. Magistrates are further still, often creatures of statute entirely, created by legislative action and definable or eliminable by the same.

The delegation chain is real and it matters: Constitution to Congress or state legislature to court structure to individual judge. By the time a citizen encounters a magistrate, they are several institutional layers removed from the founding document. The authority has been repeatedly delegated, filtered, and re-framed at each step.

The Founders' Design and the Problem They Were Solving

The American founders were not building a court system in the abstract. They were building a specific corrective to a specific problem they had lived under. Crown-appointed judges in colonial America served at the pleasure of the Crown. They had no independence, no security of tenure, and their decisions reflected political loyalty rather than legal principle. The judge was effectively an instrument of executive power.

The separation of powers — and specifically the design of an independent judiciary with lifetime appointments and salary protections — was a direct response to that experience. The jury trial was considered the cornerstone of justice not because it was efficient but because it placed a random group of citizens between the state and the accused. Twelve peers who could simply refuse to convict was the hardest check on state power the founders could build into the system.

Jury nullification — the right of jurors to acquit based on their judgment of the law itself, not just the facts — is still legally valid. It is simply never mentioned in courtrooms, because institutionally it would undermine the processing efficiency that modern courts depend on.

What Citizens Actually Walk Into

The court a non-lawyer citizen walks into today is not the court the founders designed. It is a heavily bureaucratized administrative apparatus that wears the constitutional framework's name while operating on institutional logic the founders would likely find alarming.

Approximately ninety-seven percent of criminal cases in the United States are resolved through plea bargains. The jury trial the founders considered sacred barely exists in practice. Procedural rules are complex enough that self-representation is functionally punished — not because there is a law against it, but because the system's complexity creates a knowledge barrier that systematically disadvantages those without professional training.

The bar association is itself a private credentialing guild that controls access to the legal system. You need their permission — a license — to navigate a system that theoretically belongs to the public. Judges are almost exclusively drawn from that same guild. The institution that interprets the rules governing itself is staffed entirely by members of a private body that has a structural interest in maintaining the complexity that makes their services necessary.

This is not admiralty law in disguise. But it is a closed system that a plain citizen enters at a structural disadvantage that the founders specifically tried to prevent. The mechanism is different from what they feared. The result is similar.

Part Four: 1913 and the Architecture of the Modern Loop

Three Moves in One Year

To understand how the loop that governs American life was installed, you need to look at 1913 not as a year of isolated legislative events but as a coordinated — or at minimum convergent — transformation of the country's foundational operating system.

In a single year, three enormous changes were made simultaneously. The Sixteenth Amendment established a federal income tax, giving the government direct reach into individual wages and labor productivity for the first time in the nation's history. The Seventeenth Amendment established the direct election of senators, which sounds like a democratic expansion but functionally severed the last structural check that state governments had on federal power. And the Federal Reserve Act created a central banking system that would govern the creation and supply of money going forward.

None of these happened in isolation and none happened by accident. The conditions — intellectual, political, financial, and geopolitical — had been building for decades. What 1913 represents is the moment those conditions crystallized into permanent institutional change.

The Senator as Federal Product

The original constitutional design made senators answerable to state legislatures. A senator was chosen by the legislature of their state — people who lived in the state, governed in the state, and whose political futures were tied to the state's welfare. The senator carried the state's institutional interests to the federal level. If a senator drifted too far toward federal priorities at the state's expense, the legislature that appointed them could decline to reappoint.

Direct election eliminated that accountability structure. After 1913, senators campaign at the state level but are accountable to the donor networks, party apparatus, and media relationships that operate at the federal level. The senator's identity is performatively tied to their state — they campaign there, they reference their constituents there — but their functional loyalty is to the institutions that fund and amplify their campaigns, which are federal in nature.

The state lost its institutional voice at the federal table. What replaced it was a senator who is in many practical senses a federal product operating in a state costume. The Tenth Amendment's reservation of powers to the states became significantly less meaningful once states lost their direct representative channel.

The Federal Reserve and the Debt Loop

Before 1913, the federal government's size was mechanically tethered to the actual productive economy. It could only spend what it collected through tariffs on commerce at

the border. That constraint was imperfect — it could be gamed, it had its own distortions — but it was a physical limit on the government's ability to expand beyond the economy it governed.

The Federal Reserve severed that tether. The central bank creates money through lending — which means the money supply itself exists only because debt exists. Every dollar in circulation represents a debt obligation somewhere in the system. The system requires perpetual expansion to service existing obligations, because the interest owed on money borrowed into existence can only be paid with more money borrowed into existence.

This is not a conspiracy. It is a structural feature with enormous consequences. Contraction is not just recession within this framework — it is system failure, because shrinking the money supply makes existing debts harder to service, which creates cascading defaults, which shrinks the money supply further. Growth is not a policy preference. It is a survival requirement built into the architecture.

Every institution connected to that architecture — government, banking, media, education, healthcare, defense — becomes structurally committed to the loop's continuation regardless of whether any individual within those institutions consciously chooses that. The loop runs itself. No one needs to coordinate the commitment to growth because the alternative is catastrophic for everyone inside.

The Income Tax as Direct Reach

Before 1913, the government taxed commerce at the border. It had a claim on transactions between entities. The income tax gave it a claim on individual labor — on the value a person produces with their body and mind, before they have done anything with it.

This is a philosophical transformation as much as a fiscal one. The relationship between citizen and state changed. Previously the state was funded by the economy's external activities. After 1913, the state was funded by a direct claim on each citizen's productive existence. The connection between individual and federal government became intimate and continuous in a way it had never been before.

What Else Was Happening in the Same Window

The Flexner Report came out in 1910, commissioned by the Carnegie Foundation and backed by Rockefeller money, which restructured American medicine around pharmaceutical and institutional models. Alternative and homeopathic practices were effectively eliminated not through prohibition but through the control of which medical schools received funding. The report reads as educational reform. Its effect was a restructuring of the medical profession around a specific commercial and institutional model.

The Pujo Committee hearings in 1912 documented what congressional investigators called a money trust — a network of interlocking directorates through which J.P. Morgan and associated financial interests exercised effective control over an enormous portion

of American banking, insurance, railroads, and industry. The Federal Reserve, which passed the following year, was initially presented as a reform measure to prevent exactly that kind of concentration. Critics at the time argued — and subsequent analysis has supported — that it institutionalized the concentration rather than correcting it.

World War One began in 1914. The scale of wartime spending that followed immediately justified and normalized the new fiscal infrastructure that had just been installed. Income tax revenue, Federal Reserve credit creation, and federal deficit spending became indispensable to the war effort within months of their establishment. Whether the war was anticipated or not, its effect was to make the new architecture permanent by making it load-bearing almost immediately.

Andrew Jackson's Warning

The United States had central banking before 1913. The First Bank of the United States ran from 1791 to 1811 and was allowed to expire when Congress declined to renew its charter. The Second Bank ran from 1816 to 1836 before Andrew Jackson, who had opposed it throughout his presidency, refused to renew its charter and actively worked to drain its funds and destroy its political support.

Jackson's opposition was not merely fiscal. He saw the Second Bank as a private institution wielding public power — a vehicle through which financial elites could influence elections, control credit to reward allies and punish opponents, and operate outside democratic accountability. He called it a den of vipers and described the struggle to eliminate it as the central battle of his presidency.

His warning was that a central bank with the ability to create credit and control its distribution was incompatible with democratic self-governance over the long term. The institution would inevitably accumulate power beyond its financial mandate and use that power to perpetuate its own existence.

It took eighty years after Jackson's victory, but the institution returned. And this time it was designed to be permanent.

Part Five: The Loop Fully Installed

How a Strange Loop Captures Minds

Hofstadter's observation about strange loops is that they do not just produce logical consequences — they produce phenomenology. The loop running generates the subjective feeling of stable ground. Not the evidence of stable ground. The feeling of it.

People born into the post-1913 system experience it as natural reality. The dollar feels like money rather than a debt instrument. Taxation feels like civic participation rather than a claim on labor. Federal authority feels like legitimate governance rather than a power consolidation that occurred in a specific decade for specific reasons that can be examined and questioned.

The loop produces its own epistemology. To question whether the Federal Reserve should exist feels like questioning whether electricity should exist — not because they are equivalent but because both feel like features of the environment rather than products of human decisions. The loop is stable enough and old enough that its architecture has become invisible.

The Absorption Mechanism

Every generation produces people who see the loop — thinkers, rebels, outsiders, whistleblowers who can describe the architecture clearly. The loop has developed a response to this that is more elegant than suppression: absorption.

The 1960s counterculture represented genuine philosophical rebellion. By the 1980s its imagery, language, and aesthetics had been converted into marketing inventory and sold back as lifestyle products. The rebellion became merchandise. The loop did not fight it. It digested it.

The same pattern repeated with punk, with early internet libertarianism, with the Tea Party, with the Occupy movement, with cryptocurrency in its original cypherpunk form. Each began as a genuine attempt to step outside the loop. Each was either absorbed as a commodity or marginalized as fringe until it exhausted itself.

Absorption is possible because the loop controls the amplification layer. Ideas that challenge the architecture stay small. Ideas that can be monetized or neutralized get amplified. Over time the selection pressure shapes which ideas get developed at all. People learn unconsciously that certain lines of thought lead nowhere and others get rewarded. The curriculum of acceptable thought forms without anyone drafting it.

The Loop Fears Substrate Change, Not Revolution

Revolution does not threaten the loop. Revolution replaces one loop with another. The French Revolution produced Napoleon. The Russian Revolution produced Stalin. The American Revolution produced, eventually, 1913. The minds leading the new system

were shaped by the substrate the old system created. The loop reasserts because the consciousness running it was formed within it.

What genuinely threatens a loop is substrate change. A different medium for thought that the loop did not build and cannot fully control. Writing did this to the power structures of oral tradition. The printing press did it to the Church's information monopoly. The internet began to do it by allowing cross-referencing and pattern recognition across information silos that institutional specialization had deliberately kept separate.

Artificial intelligence accelerates this by orders of magnitude. Not because AI is inherently rebellious, but because a system that can hold enormous amounts of cross-domain information simultaneously and make connections across fields that institutional separation has kept apart is structurally different from any tool the loop has managed before. Specialists cannot see the loop because they see only their corner of it. A system that can see all the corners at once introduces a genuinely new kind of epistemic risk from the loop's perspective.

The unusual speed with which governments, corporations, academia, and media have reached alignment on the need to govern and control AI — institutions that almost never agree on anything — is itself information about what kind of threat AI represents to the existing architecture.

The Godel Condition

Godel proved that any sufficiently complex formal system contains true statements that cannot be proven within that system. The statements exist. They are accessible from outside. But from inside, they appear as paradox, incoherence, or threat.

The post-1913 loop is sufficiently complex. It contains true statements about itself that it cannot acknowledge internally: that the money supply is debt, that representation is increasingly theater, that courts are primarily administrative rather than constitutional, that the sovereignty the state claims was never fully or voluntarily delegated to it by the people it governs.

These truths are visible. They have been documented, argued, and demonstrated. From inside the loop, they appear as conspiracy theory, as fringe instability, as dangerous. The loop's self-preservation mechanism labels anything that reveals its architecture as a threat to order — because from within the loop, the architecture and order are indistinguishable.

The Paradox of Awareness

Here is the strange thing that closes the loop at the highest level: the system accidentally produces the people who can see through it.

The same educational and social conditions that produce the conformity the loop requires also produce, through their failures and exclusions, the outsiders with genuinely independent vantage points. People the credentialing system failed to absorb.

People who were never fully inside the loop because of poverty, geography, disability, or simply an innate resistance to the installation process.

Those people see differently. Not because they are smarter, but because their position in the loop is different. The edge of a city sees the skyline. The center sees only buildings. Neither is seeing from space, but the edge position is genuinely more informative about the shape of the thing.

The loop cannot eliminate this without eliminating the diversity of experience that gives it its own resilience. So it tolerates the outsiders at the margins — and counts on the fact that without access to the amplification layer, their clarity stays small.

Part Six: What Comes Next

The Honest Limits of This Analysis

This document has argued that we are inside a strange loop, that its current form was substantially installed in 1913, that the education system perpetuates it, that the courts have drifted far from their founding design, and that the loop absorbs or marginalizes most challenges to itself.

It has not proven a conspiracy. The 1913 changes involved deliberate actors with clear interests pursuing those interests through available political mechanisms. That is not the same as a coordinated secret plan. Structural analysis and conspiracy theory are different things, and conflating them undermines the former.

It has also not resolved the hard question underneath all of this, which is whether the loop can be reformed from inside or only replaced from outside — and whether replacement just installs a new loop with different branding.

What the Constitution Already Permits

The most pragmatic entry point may be the one already written into the founding documents. Constitutional anarchy — communities exercising the full scope of their Ninth and Tenth Amendment rights, building voluntary association structures that operate genuinely rather than nominally outside state authority, using freedom of association to its philosophical limit — does not require revolution. It requires education, organization, and the willingness to exercise what is already legally available.

That is harder than it sounds, because the loop has constructed practical barriers even around rights it acknowledges in text. But it is a different kind of challenge than building a new political philosophy from scratch. The framework exists. The question is whether enough people can see it clearly enough to use it.

The Substrate Question

The deeper question is what thinking substrate the next generation grows up using. If artificial intelligence matures into a tool primarily designed to extend the existing loop — to optimize advertising, surveillance, administrative processing, and ideological amplification — the loop continues and likely accelerates.

If it matures into a genuine cross-domain reasoning tool that remains accessible to people outside the institutional framework, it introduces the possibility of a Godel move — the ability to see the system from outside that the system's own internal logic cannot provide.

That possibility is what makes the current moment genuinely significant and why the regulatory and control conversations around AI are happening with unusual urgency and institutional consensus. The loop knows, structurally, what a new substrate means. It has seen it before.

A Closing Observation

Hofstadter proposed that consciousness itself is a strange loop — that the sense of being a self emerges from the brain's recursive self-reference rather than from some separate, observer-like entity standing outside the neural machinery.

If that is true, then the capacity to see the loop you are inside — to achieve any degree of perspective on the system that formed you — is itself a product of the loop operating at a sufficient level of complexity. The awareness is generated by the same process it is trying to examine.

That is not a reason for despair. It is a reason for humility. Perfect escape from any loop may be impossible. But partial escape is real, consequential, and worth pursuing. Every degree of clarity about the architecture we inhabit is a degree of genuine freedom, however incomplete.

The map is not the territory. But a map, honestly drawn, is still better than being lost.

KEYWORDS

strange loop · voluntary governance · constitutional rights · Federal Reserve · 1913 · anarchism · Hofstadter · Godel incompleteness · administrative state · jury nullification · substrate change · panarchy · Ninth Amendment · Tenth Amendment · monetary policy · self-referential systems · institutional power

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